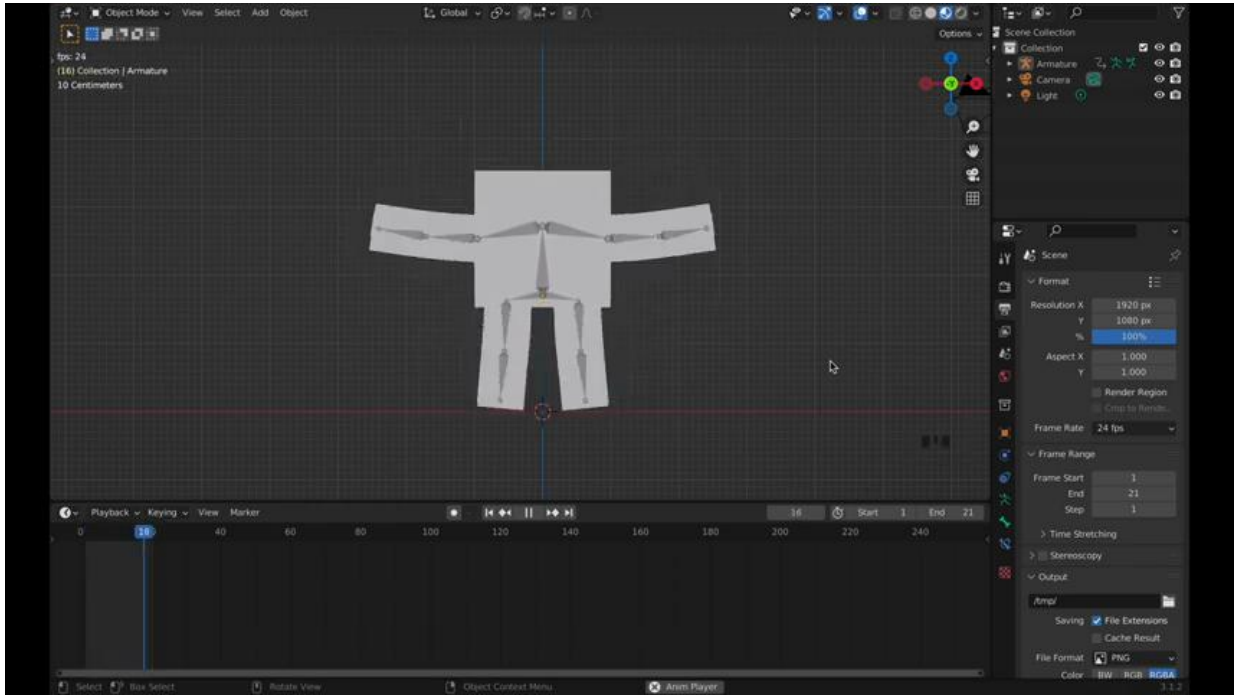
3D Creative Club Study Guide

Animating a Character

Goal: What You Will Make

Object Mode



Steps:

- Open the teacher's rigged character model
- Pose the bones and insert keyframes
- Play the animation in the timeline
- Place a camera and render a short clip

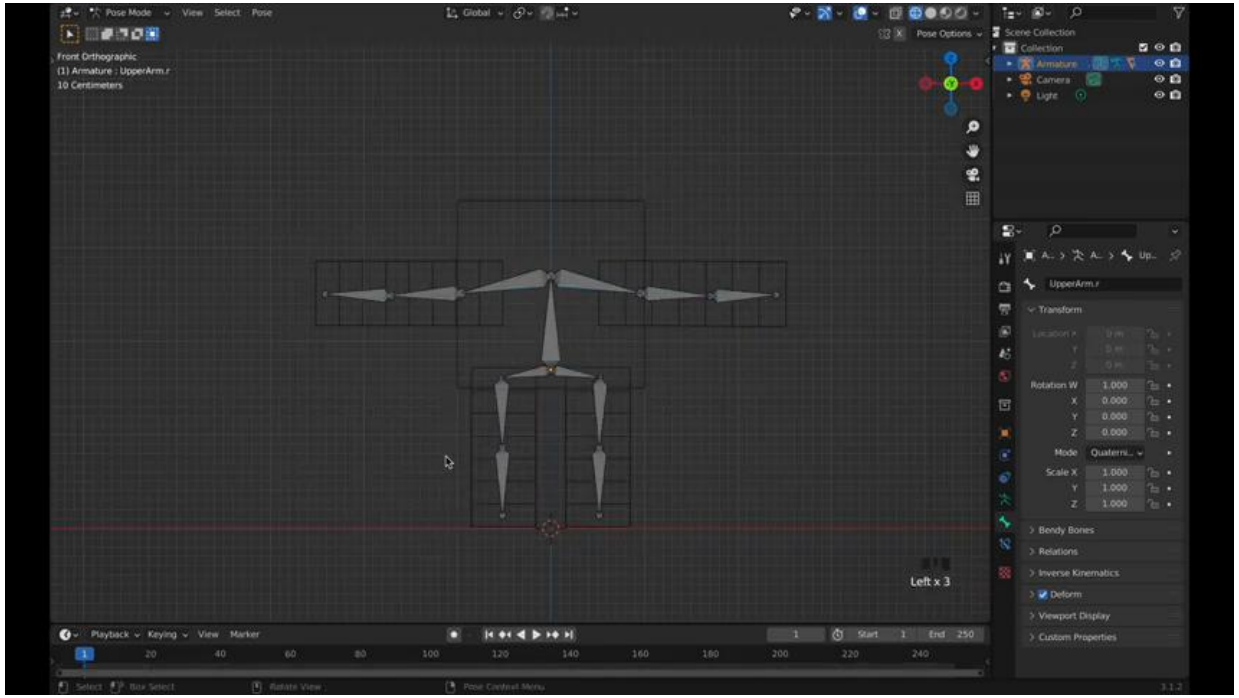
Shortcuts:

I: Insert keyframe · Spacebar: Play · Ctrl + F12: Render animation

Tip: The armature is already built; this guide starts at the keyframe step.

Step 0: Open the Rigged Model

Object Mode



Steps:

- Open the .blend file from the teacher / shared drive
- Select the Armature object in the scene
- Make sure you are in Object Mode first

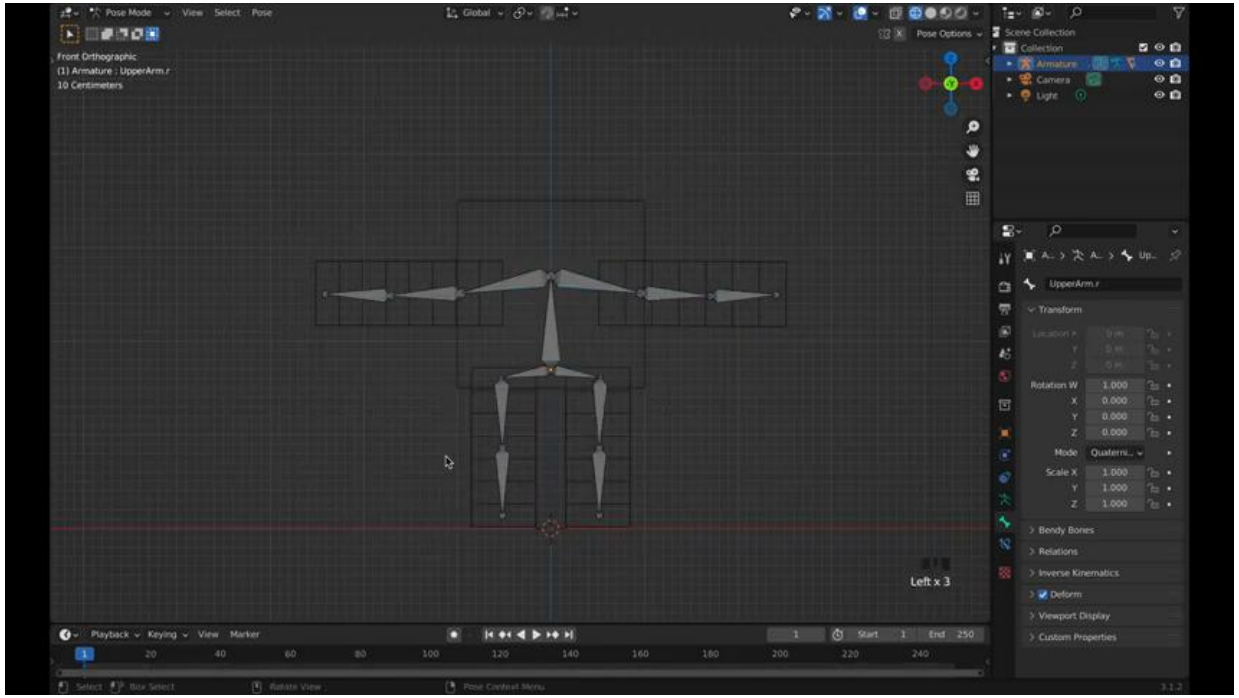
Shortcuts:

No shortcut — File → Open

Tip: Shared computers may not save your work; keep your rendered output at the end.

Step 1: Switch to Pose Mode

Pose Mode



Steps:

- Select the Armature
- Top-left dropdown: Object Mode → Pose Mode
- Or press Ctrl + Tab with the armature selected
- Click a bone to select it

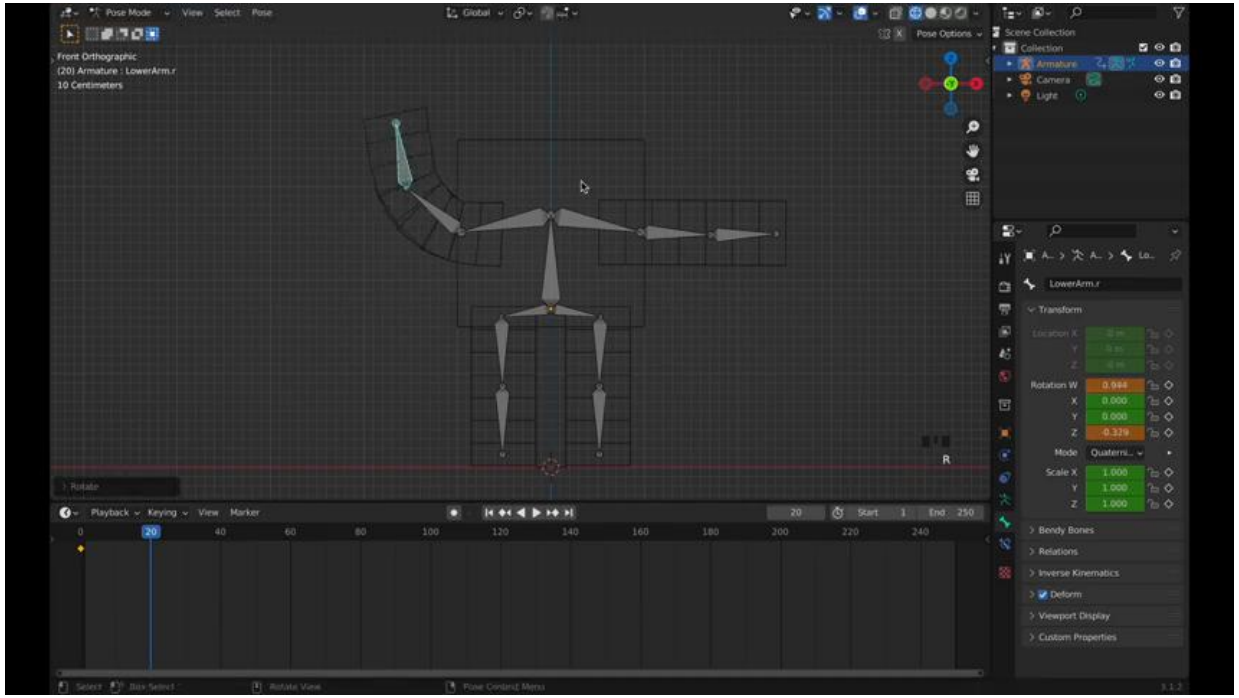
Shortcuts:

Ctrl + Tab: Pose Mode · Click: Select bone

Tip: In Pose Mode you move bones, not the mesh itself.

Step 2: Rotate Bones to Pose

Pose Mode



Steps:

- Select a bone
- Press R to rotate freely
- Press R + X / Y / Z to rotate on one axis only
- Left-click to confirm the rotation

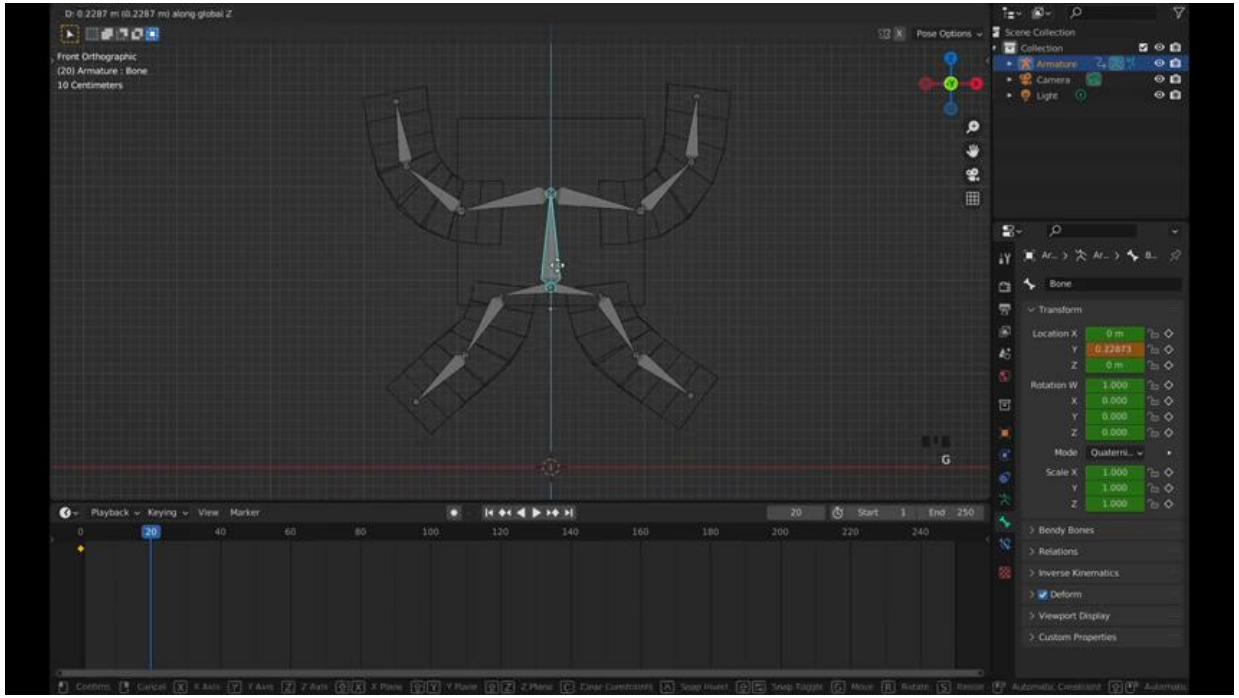
Shortcuts:

R: Rotate · R + X/Y/Z: Axis rotate

Tip: Start with arms and legs; small rotations look more natural.

Step 3: Insert the First Keyframe

Pose Mode



Steps:

- Make sure the timeline is at frame 1
- Select all bones you moved (A to select all)
- Press I and choose Rotation (or Location & Rotation)
- A yellow keyframe diamond appears on the timeline

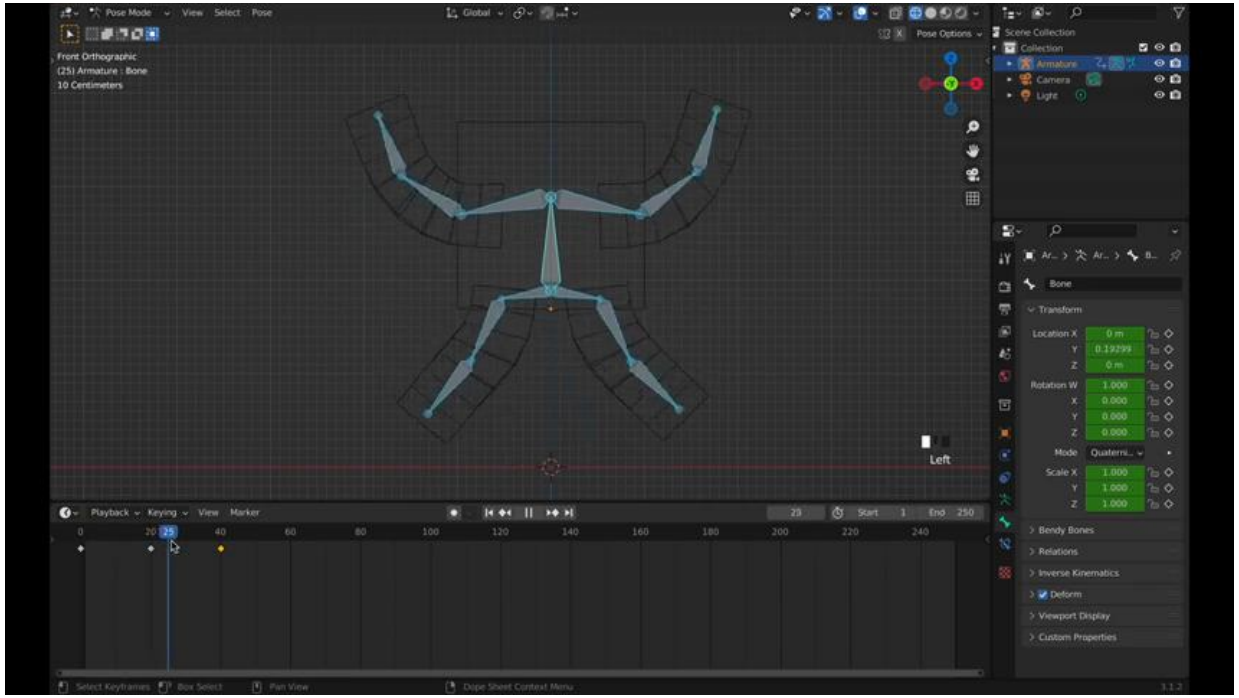
Shortcuts:

I: Insert keyframe · A: Select all bones

Tip: If you only rotated bones, choose Rotation. If you also moved them, choose LocRot.

Step 4: Add More Keyframes

Pose Mode



Steps:

- Move the playhead to frame 20 or 30
- Pose the character in a new position
- Press I → Rotation again
- Repeat for more poses across the timeline

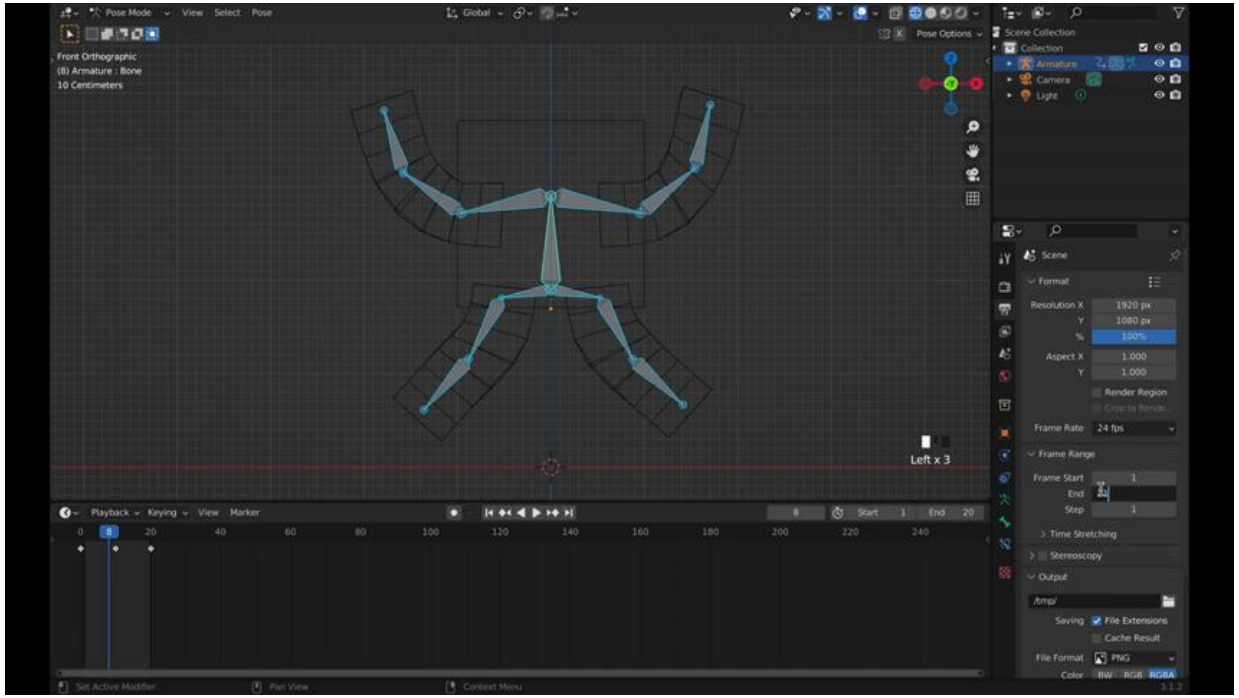
Shortcuts:

Left/Right arrow: Move 1 frame · Shift + Up/Down: Jump keyframe

Tip: More keyframes = smoother but more work; 3–4 poses is enough for a first try.

Step 5: Set Frame Range & Playback

Object Mode



Steps:

- In the Output Properties, set Frame Start to 1 and End to your last frame (e.g., 60)
- Or drag the timeline start/end markers
- Press Spacebar to play
- Watch the character move between poses

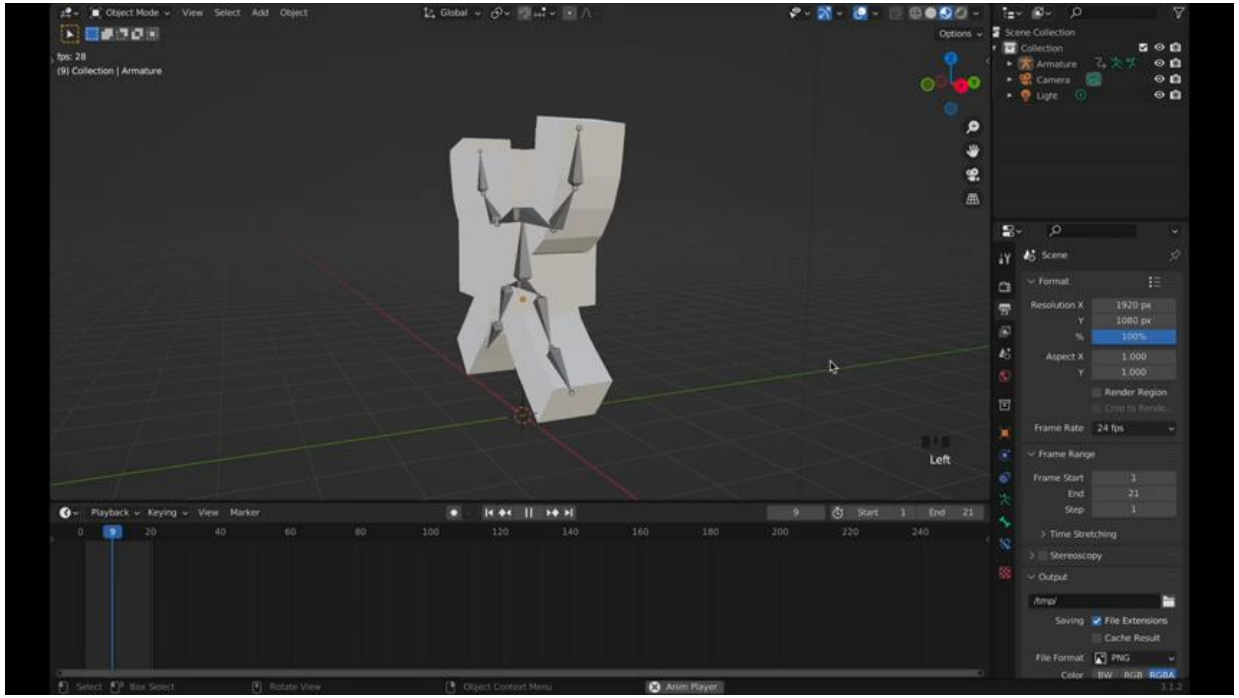
Shortcuts:

Spacebar: Play / pause · End: Jump to last frame

Tip: If playback is choppy, lower the viewport quality or use a shorter range.

Step 6: Place the Camera

Object Mode



Steps:

- Select the Camera object in the scene
- Use G / R / S to move, rotate and aim it
- Press the ` (backtick) key and choose Camera to view through it
- Adjust until the full character fits in the frame

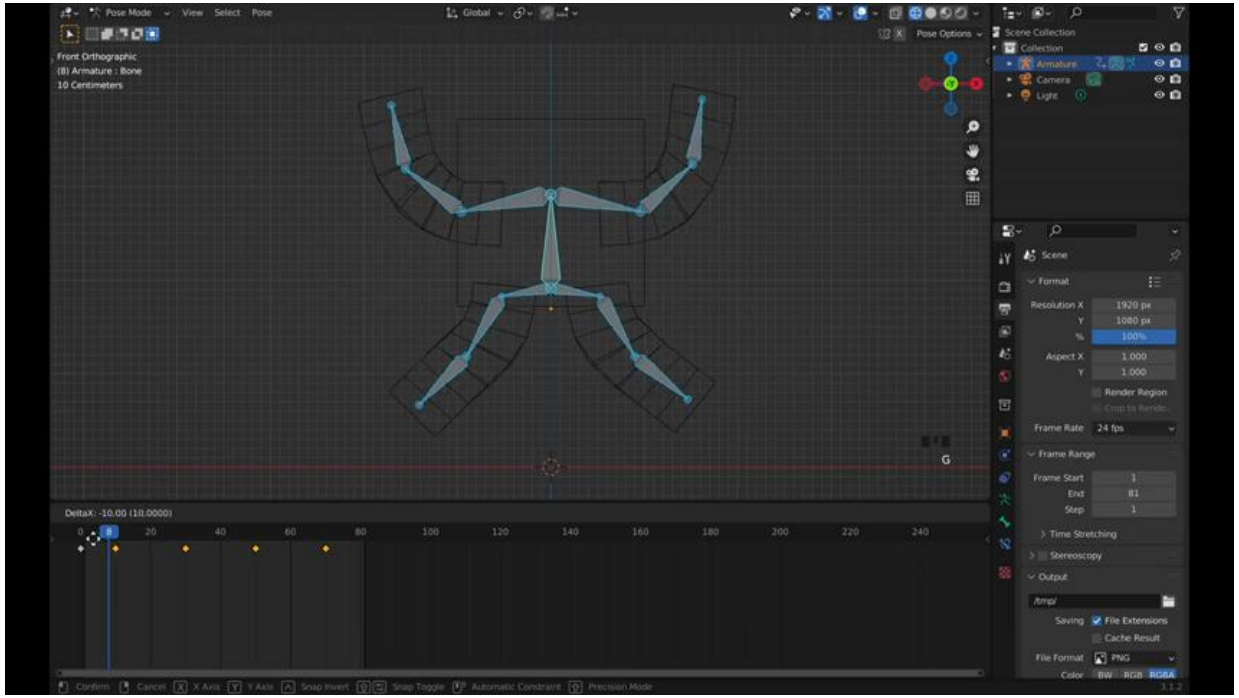
Shortcuts:

` (backtick): View selector · G/R/S: Move/rotate/scale camera

Tip: You can also enable 'Camera to View' in the sidebar (N) and move the view.

Step 7: Render Animation

Object Mode



Steps:

- Open Output Properties (printer icon)
- Set file format to FFmpeg video or PNG sequence
- Choose an output folder you can access
- Press Ctrl + F12 to render the animation

Shortcuts:

Ctrl + F12: Render animation

Tip: PNG sequence is safer for shared computers; you can combine it into a video later.

Shortcut Cheat Sheet

Tab / Ctrl + Tab	Object / Pose Mode	**R / R + X/Y/Z**	Rotate bone / axis	**G / G + X/Y/Z**	Move object / bone
I	Insert keyframe	**Left / Right**	Previous / next frame	**Shift + Up / Down**	Jump to keyframe
Spacebar	Play / pause animation	**` (backtick)**	View selector	**N**	Toggle sidebar
Ctrl + F12	Render animation				